Ratan could hardly conceal his joy. The date was a memorable one for him for another reason too, though he said nothing of it; it is doubtful if he even made the connection—it was on this day, seventeen years ago, that he had taken over as chairman, Tata Sons. He received many messages including one from David Cameron, then leader of the Conservative Party who would become the UK prime minister two years later. Cameron congratulated Ratan for acquiring 'two of the UK's leading car brands', which were 'incredibly important British businesses with a long heritage'.

But the opposition to the Tatas buying the brands did not end. On the day after the agreement was signed, ABC News went to great lengths to deride Ratan, stating that he could not have got it more wrong. The former chairman of American Motors, Gerald Meyers, appeared on the channel championing that view. He said: 'It's one of the most illogical buys I could imagine.' He was 'not sure Tata knows what it's gotten itself into'. He added that it could take $10 billion to 'straighten out the product line-up and then a few billion more to expand distribution globally'.

Rebecca Lindland, an analyst at IHS Global Insight, a Massachusetts-based economic and financial analysis company, mocked the acquisition saying, 'It's a little bit like Walmart buying Prada. Jaguar and Land Rover need a buyer that appreciates their heritage and can restore their glory, especially to Jaguar … It's hard to say whether Tata is that company.' Others wondered how the Tatas could succeed where Ford had failed when, despite its large size and history as a car maker, it had not been able to make a success of Jaguar and Land Rover (in 2007, Ford's revenue was nearly six times that of the entire Tata Group).

The Western critics particularly were at a loss to comprehend what a third-world car company would do with two loss-making luxury car brands. In addition, it was a time when the US market for luxury cars was generally heading south. But Ratan was not giving up. It is not in his character. He readied himself and his team for squarely meeting the criticisms.

In a letter to Kant on 26 March 2008, Ratan appreciated his leadership during the acquisition process. But he also cautioned, 'In some ways, this is only the start of what could be a challenging road ahead in transitioning Tata Motors' mindset from an India-centric enterprise to a global company in a tremendously competitive high-cost, high-risk sector.'

One of the first things Ratan did after acquiring the marquee brands was to tour the US. It was characteristic of him to engage with his detractors and